

Maintain the Right View of Adversity

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Song 122 & 150 | "Though distress and difficulty come upon me, I remain fond of your commandments."

— Psalm 119:143

THE RIGHT VIEW OF ADVERSITY

1-2. What do we need to do in order to deal with our adversities successfully? (See also picture.)

DIRECT: We need to maintain the RIGHT view of our problems. Hardship is normal in this system — "the beginning of pang of distress" was foretold (**Matthew 24:8**), wicked people keep getting worse (**2 Timothy 3:13**), and "time and unexpected events" can hit any of us. (**Ecclesiastes 9:12**) If we expect trials and view them correctly, they won't crush us.

DEEPER: Notice that Jesus called these troubles "pangs of distress" — like a woman in labor. (**Matthew 24:8**) Labor pains are painful but PURPOSEFUL; they signal that something new is about to be born. In ministry, this is a comforting picture to share: the very troubles that frighten people are actually proof that Jehovah's promised new world is near.

3. What must we accept about life in this wicked system?

DIRECT: We must accept that problems are unavoidable right now. Jesus foretold "pangs of distress" (**Matthew 24:8**), Paul said wicked men "will advance from bad to worse" (**2 Timothy 3:13**), and Solomon noted that "time and unexpected events" overtake everyone. (**Ecclesiastes 9:12**) Trouble is not a sign Jehovah has abandoned us — it is simply the nature of these last days.

DEEPER: **Ecclesiastes 9:12** says calamity can fall "suddenly," like a bird caught in a trap. This teaches realism, not fear. Jehovah does not hide the truth from us about life now — he prepares us for it. A friend who tells you the hard truth in advance is a true friend; that is the kind of God Jehovah is.

4. What additional hardships do Christians face?

DIRECT: Beyond normal life troubles, Christians face persecution. Jesus warned we would be hated and even killed (**Matthew 24:9; John 16:2**), and Paul said tribulation is "what we are destined" for. (**1 Thessalonians 3:3, 4**) Satan challenged whether anyone would serve God under pressure (**Job 1:9-11**), so our faithfulness actually answers his taunt. (**Proverbs 27:11**)

DEEPER: **Proverbs 27:11** reveals something deeply personal: our endurance lets Jehovah "make a reply to him who taunts me." This teaches that our faithful response to hardship is not just about our own survival — it brings JOY to Jehovah's heart and vindicates his name. In ministry, this gives dignity to every trial we endure.

5. What can we learn from Ecclesiastes 7:13, 14?

DIRECT: We learn to accept both good days and bad days. **Ecclesiastes 7:13, 14** says to "be in good spirits" on a good day, but on a bad day to "reflect" — God made both. It does NOT mean God causes our troubles; **James 1:13** says God tests no one with evil. We accept that life has hard days without blaming Jehovah for them.

DEEPER: **Ecclesiastes 7:14** urges us to "reflect" on a difficult day. This teaches that adversity has value when we let it make us think — about our priorities, our dependence on Jehovah, our hope. A bad day, viewed correctly, can do something a good day cannot: it can draw us closer to God.

6. Why might Jehovah allow us to face trials?

DIRECT: Trials can train and refine us. **Hebrews 12:7, 11** compares it to a father's discipline that later yields "peaceable fruit." Jehovah is with us through it (**Psalms 23:4**), just as Job came to know God better through his suffering. (**Job 42:1-6**) And nothing we endure can separate us from God's love. (**Romans 8:35-39**)

DEEPER: Job said, "Now my own eye does see you." (**Job 42:5**) He knew ABOUT God before, but his trial made God REAL to him. This teaches that adversity can deepen our relationship with Jehovah in a way comfort never could. The closeness we gain is worth more than the pain it cost — and **Romans 8:39** assures us that closeness can never be broken.

7. Why can you be happy even when you are persecuted for your faith?

DIRECT: Because Jesus said the persecuted are "happy" and have a great reward in heaven. (**Matthew 5:10-12**) The apostles even rejoiced at being beaten for Jesus' name. (**Acts 5:40-42**) Our fine conduct under attack honors God (**1 Peter 2:12**), and like Joseph in prison, "Jehovah was with him" the whole time. (**Genesis 39:3, 23**)

DEEPER: **Genesis 39:23** says Jehovah made everything Joseph did succeed — even in prison. This teaches that Jehovah's presence is not limited to good circumstances; he is just as near in the dungeon as in the palace. In ministry, this reassures the suffering: your hardest place is not a place where God is absent — it may be where he is closest.

8. What further incentive do we have to endure our trials?

DIRECT: The certainty of a blessed outcome. Jehovah "blessed the last part of Job's life more than the beginning" (**Job 42:12**), and Jesus promised "the one who has endured to the end will be saved." (**Matthew 24:13**) Our trials are temporary; the reward is permanent.

DEEPER: **Matthew 24:13** ties salvation not to never falling, but to ENDURING. This teaches that Jehovah does not require a perfect life — he asks for a faithful one that keeps going. Endurance is simply love that refuses to quit. Every day we hold on is a day we prove that love, and Jehovah remembers every one of them.

HOW A WRONG VIEW CAN HARM US

9. How could a wrong view of our adversity harm us?

DIRECT: It can make us bitter or wrongly blame God. Elihu noticed that Job "declared his own soul righteous rather than God." (**Job 32:2**) Naomi felt that "the Almighty has made my life very bitter." (**Ruth 1:13, 20, 21**) **Proverbs 19:3** warns that "the foolishness of a man... his heart rages against Jehovah" — blaming God for trouble he did not cause.

DEEPER: **Proverbs 19:3** describes a person who ruins his own way, then blames God for it. This teaches a subtle danger: in pain, our hearts can drift toward resenting the very One who wants to help us. Recognizing this tendency in advance protects our relationship with Jehovah — so that adversity draws us TO him, not away.

10. When we are under trial, what might we begin to wonder about?

DIRECT: We might wonder if Jehovah is even listening. The Bible is honest: **Proverbs 24:10** notes our strength can shrink in distress; the psalmist asked, "Why, O Jehovah, do you stand far off?" (**Psalm 10:1**); Habakkuk cried, "How long must I cry... and you do not hear?" (**Habakkuk 1:2**) Yet **Psalm 10:17** assures us Jehovah DOES hear the desire of the meek.

DEEPER: Notice that these honest, raw questions are recorded IN the Bible. (**Psalm 10:1; Habakkuk 1:2**) This teaches that Jehovah is not offended by our honest struggles — he preserved them in his Word so we'd know we are not alone in feeling them. And **Psalm 10:17** answers the doubt: he hears even when it feels like silence.

11. What could happen to us if we do not have the correct view of trials?

DIRECT: We could be caught off guard and stumble. **1 Peter 4:12** says not to be "puzzled" by trials as though something strange were happening. Even the apostles failed to grasp Jesus' coming suffering (**Luke 18:33, 34; Mark 8:31-33**) until he opened the Scriptures to them and their hearts "burned." (**Luke 24:25-27, 32, 44-48**)

DEEPER: After his resurrection, Jesus patiently reasoned from "all the Scriptures" to help the disciples understand. (**Luke 24:27**) This teaches that the cure for confusion in hardship is God's Word. When trials don't make sense, opening the Scriptures — as Jesus did — can make our hearts "burn" again with understanding and hope.

12. How could a wrong view of our situation make us feel?

DIRECT: It can make us feel that we have been treated unfairly. In Jesus' illustration, the workers who labored all day grumbled even though they got exactly what was agreed. (**Matthew 20:10-13**) A wrong view makes us compare ourselves with others and feel cheated, even when Jehovah has been completely fair and generous to us.

DEEPER: The landowner replied, "Did you not agree with me?" (**Matthew 20:13**) The workers' joy was stolen not by injustice but by comparison. This teaches a quiet truth: discontent often grows not from what we lack, but from what we think others have. Gratitude, not comparison, keeps our view of Jehovah's dealings clear.

STEPS WE CAN TAKE WHEN ADVERSITY STRIKES

13. What might happen when adversity strikes?

DIRECT: Adversity can come suddenly and overwhelm us emotionally, making it hard to think clearly or remember Jehovah's help. That is why we need to prepare NOW — deciding in advance how we will respond — so that when trouble hits, we act on faith rather than react in panic.

DEEPER: The very fact that the article urges advance preparation teaches us something about wise faith: trust in Jehovah is built BEFORE the storm, not during it. Like a tree that grows deep roots in calm weather so it can stand in the wind, our daily closeness to Jehovah becomes the strength we draw on when adversity strikes.

14. What can you pray for when you are suffering?

DIRECT: Pray for the strength to endure. Paul said, "I have strength for all things by virtue of him who imparts power to me." (**Philippians 4:13**) Jehovah can do "more than superabundantly beyond all the things we ask." (**Ephesians 3:20**) And his angel "camps all around those fearing him." (**Psalms 34:7**)

DEEPER: **Ephesians 3:20** says Jehovah gives MORE than we even ask. This teaches that our prayers in suffering are never too big — they are often too small. We ask just to survive; Jehovah wants to give us peace, growth, and closeness on top of it. In ministry, this enlarges how we teach others to pray: not timidly, but trusting a generous Father.

15. What will help you to endure adversity? (See also picture.)

DIRECT: Staying close to Jehovah's Word and his people. The theme text says, "Though distress and difficulty come upon me, I remain fond of your commandments." (**Psalms 119:143**) And **Proverbs 18:1** warns that the one who isolates himself acts against practical wisdom — so we must NOT pull away when we hurt.

DEEPER: **Psalms 119:143** shows the psalmist clinging to God's commandments precisely WHILE in distress. This teaches that the time we most feel like withdrawing from spiritual things is exactly when we most need them. And **Proverbs 18:1** warns against isolation — Jehovah designed the congregation as a support system, and leaning on it in hardship is wisdom, not weakness.

16. What doubts might you face when adversity strikes, and how can you resolve them?

DIRECT: Satan may plant doubts about whether God values you or whether obedience is worth it. We "overturn reasonings" that oppose the knowledge of God. (2 Corinthians 10:4, 5) Paul endured incredible hardship yet stayed faithful (2 Corinthians 11:23-27), and we recall that Jehovah blots out our sins (Isaiah 43:25), loves his law (Psalm 119:97), and guards those who take refuge in him. (Psalm 91:9-12)

DEEPER: Isaiah 43:25 is stunning: Jehovah says he wipes out our transgressions "for my own sake." This teaches that God's forgiveness flows from WHO HE IS, not merely from what we deserve. When doubts whisper that we are not worth saving, this verse silences them — Jehovah's mercy is anchored in his own loving nature, not in our perfection.

17. What should we do when adversity strikes?

DIRECT: Reflect, rely on Jehovah, and remember that the trial is temporary. Ecclesiastes 7:14 tells us to reflect on the difficult day, and 1 Corinthians 10:13 promises God "will not let you be tempted beyond what you can bear" but will "make the way out" so we can endure it.

DEEPER: 1 Corinthians 10:13 promises not the REMOVAL of the trial, but a "way out" — the strength to endure it. This teaches that Jehovah's help often comes not by erasing the problem, but by carrying us THROUGH it. In ministry, this is honest hope to offer: God may not take away every hardship now, but he guarantees no faithful servant will ever face more than they can bear with his help.

HOW WOULD YOU ANSWER?

What can help us to have the right view of adversity?

DIRECT: Accepting that trials are normal in this system (Matthew 24:8; Ecclesiastes 9:12), understanding that Jehovah allows them to refine us (Hebrews 12:7, 11), and remembering that endurance leads to a blessed outcome. (Job 42:12; Matthew 24:13)

DEEPER: The right view sees adversity through Jehovah's eyes — as a labor pain announcing the new world (Matthew 24:8), and as something that, like Job's trial, can make God real to us. (Job 42:5) Pain handled with faith becomes a bridge closer to our Father, not a wall between us.

How can a wrong view of our situation harm us?

DIRECT: It can make us bitter, blame Jehovah for troubles he didn't cause (**Proverbs 19:3; Ruth 1:20, 21**), feel cheated by comparing ourselves to others (**Matthew 20:10-13**), and even stumble when caught off guard. (**1 Peter 4:12**)

DEEPER: **Proverbs 19:3** warns that a person can ruin his own path, then let his heart "rage against Jehovah." This teaches the quiet danger of pain: it can turn our hearts against the very One who wants to help. Guarding our view protects the most precious thing we have — our friendship with God.

What can we do when adversity strikes?

DIRECT: Pray for strength (**Philippians 4:13; Ephesians 3:20**), stay close to God's Word and his people (**Psalms 119:143; Proverbs 18:1**), reject Satan's doubts (**2 Corinthians 10:4, 5**), and remember the trial is temporary. (**1 Corinthians 10:13**)

DEEPER: **1 Corinthians 10:13** promises a "way out" so we can endure — not always escape, but always endurance. This teaches that Jehovah's faithfulness is the one certainty in every storm: he will never allow a faithful servant to be tested beyond what, with his help, they can bear.